

A LEGEND'S GOODBYE

Sunil Chhetri **ended a remarkable career** with an emotional farewell match at the Salt Lake Stadium but without the dream victory he and his fans had hoped for.



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On the evening of June 6, 2024, over a cup of tea, a curious hotel manager walked up to a waiting customer and greeted him before asking, "If you don't mind... If I ask you to come up with two topics of interest to discuss, what would they be?"

The man at the table quickly replied, "Sunil Chhetri's retirement." He then asked, "Where is the hullabaloo about Chhetri's [India] retirement? If [Sachin] Tendulkar were playing his last game, would there be such little excitement?"

Hours before Chhetri's final game in India colours, several parallels could be drawn between his and Tendulkar's careers. Both are celebrated stars in their respective sports, having played at the highest level for over two decades. But that's where the comparison ends.

Tendulkar was a larger-than-life personality who captured the imagination of over a billion people whenever he held a bat. Many times, Chhetri has scaled every blade of grass, putting in real effort for the national team, only to be met with apathy from nearly a billion people.

But for his final game, Chhetri didn't need to make an impassioned plea for people to attend. The match, an important World Cup qualifier, was at the Salt Lake Stadium in Kolkata. Leading up to the game, there was buzz about the strong 60,000+ crowd expected to make it a memorable night for Indian football.

Fans of all ages came from everywhere. Toshupta Bhattacharya travelled two hours from Kolaghat with his

young son. "Our hopes are very high for this game," he said. Chandradeep from Kolkata, watching his first India game live, reflected, "I am really emotional. My first India match will be his last match."

If the team had won, they would have sung into the night with Chhetri parading around the Salt Lake Stadium. His warm-up walkout was accompanied by the army band and a thunderous roar of "Chhetri! Chhetri!"

After the Indian national anthem, banners were unfurled around the stands. One read, "Thank you, Sunil

